

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Digital monitor programs to change

Officials poised to make alterations, but few details available

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

Earlier this month, at around 4:30 a.m., Chicago police officers noticed a car with a broken headlight and initiated a stop. The officers spotted a black bag on the floorboard, felt an L-shaped object, according to prosecutors, and found a loaded pistol with a defaced serial number.

The 34-year-old man charged with a gun felony then became one of the newest of the roughly 1,500 people currently on the Cook County sheriff's office's electronic monitoring program.

Another approximately 1,900 people are on separate electronic monitoring programs operated under the court system, including one geared toward domestic violence offenses.

Experts and county stakeholders have long criticized the parallel electronic monitoring programs as wasteful, with Cook County as one of the only jurisdictions in the country that splits resources in this way.

"It's a historical artifact, just that the two programs were created at different times essentially," said Sarah Staudt, an attorney who consults with the Illinois Network for Pretrial Justice. "It's fundamentally inefficient."

Now, the county is making moves to merge the programs under the auspices of the chief judge's office, rather than the sheriff's office — a move that Sheriff Tom Dart has long pushed for and Chief Judge Tim Evans has resisted.

The proposed changes follow years of debate about electronic monitoring, with

Turn to Monitors, Page 4

'We are not alone'

Local 'Blue Christmas' services offer solace for those who grieve, struggle during the holidays

By Angie Leventis Lourgos | Chicago Tribune

Elena and Kevin Shuff had 17 days with their son Michael Kevin before the newborn's death on Dec. 26, 2022.

The Advent season is a period of complicated emotions for the north suburban couple.

They recall the elation of becoming parents after the birth of their only child, who came into the world precariously early on Dec. 9, weighing just 2 pounds.

"It was the most joyous time in our lives," Kevin Shuff said. "It was hope, peace, joy and love."

Yet they simultaneously mourn the end of his short life, which fell the day after Christmas.

Zoe Sundstrom sings a hymn at a Blue Christmas service to offer solace for worshippers during the holiday season at Our Lady of Perpetual Help Parish in Glenview on Dec. 18. Blue Christmas events are often held on or around the winter solstice, the shortest day and longest night of the year, for many a time of reflection.

TESS CROWLEY/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

"Knowing he is in heaven is a comfort; knowing we have a saint looking down on us," he added. "But knowing that doesn't make up for all the memories we couldn't create together."

The mother and father were among the roughly five dozen worshippers who attended the first "Blue Christmas" service at Our Lady of Perpetual Help Parish in Glenview on Wednesday, which was designed to offer a message of healing for those who are grieving, lonely or sorrowful during the holidays.

Blue Christmas services — also called the Longest Night services — are often held on or around the winter solstice, which fell on Saturday this year in the Northern Hemisphere. The date marks the longest night and shortest day of the year, symbolizing a dark time of life as well as the assurance that the days will

Turn to Christmas, Page 3

US: 2 Navy pilots shot down by 'friendly fire'

Both alive after incident over Red Sea

By Jon Gambrell
Associated Press

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — Two U.S. Navy pilots were shot down Sunday over the Red Sea in an apparent "friendly fire" incident, the U.S. military said, marking the most serious incident to threaten troops in over a year of America targeting Yemen's Houthi rebels.

Both pilots were recovered alive after ejecting from their stricken aircraft, with one suffering minor injuries. But the shootdown underlines just how dangerous the Red Sea corridor has become, with ongoing attacks on shipping by the Iranian-backed Houthis despite

U.S. and European military coalitions patrolling the area.

The U.S. military had conducted airstrikes targeting Yemen's Houthi rebels at the time of the friendly fire incident, though the U.S. military's Central Command did not elaborate on what the pilots' mission was and did not respond to questions from The Associated Press.

The F/A-18 shot down had just flown off the deck of the USS Harry S. Truman aircraft carrier, Central Command said. On Dec. 15, Central Command acknowledged the Truman had entered the Mideast, but hadn't specified that the carrier and its battle group was in the Red Sea.

"The guided-missile cruiser USS Gettysburg, which is part of

Turn to Pilots, Page 9



West Side middle schooler Camarria Williams, left, and her twin, Camerria, are shown at James R. Jordan Boys & Girls Club on Dec. 20. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

North Lawndale middle schooler helps make scientific discovery

Girl, 11, finds molecule with cancer-fighting properties in goose poop

By Sylvan Lebrun
Chicago Tribune

In Garfield Park, Camarria Williams has often enjoyed walks with her mom. There, the 11-year-old girl also discovered a new cancer-fighting molecule in an unexpected source: goose poop.

Williams and her twin sister, Camerria, who attend William H. Brown STEM Magnet School, spent the fall of 2022 participating in a science program at a West Side Boys & Girls Club where they worked with researchers to identify potential antibiotics that occur in nature.

The twins from North Lawndale were part of the third cohort of middle school students who participated in the Chicago Antibiotic Discovery Lab, a partnership between the Boys & Girls

Club and a University of Illinois Chicago lab run by pharmaceutical sciences professor Brian Murphy.

During a field trip to Garfield Park to collect samples rich in bacteria, Williams knew exactly where to look. She thought back to memories of feeding the park's geese with her mother, she said.

"The reason I got the poop was because the geese eat everything," Williams said.

Turn to Discovery, Page 2



INSIDE

Bears lose to Lions, 34-17

The Lions capitalized on Bears mistakes Sunday in Chicago, surging ahead early to a 20-0 lead and forcing the Bears to play catch-up. Bears quarterback Caleb Williams, left, threw for 334 yards — the third-highest output of his rookie season — and two touchdowns.

Chicago Sports

TODAY'S
WEATHER



High 39 Low 32

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

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